

GAME ON PM Modi with India's top gamers in Delhi, Apr. 11

tion (ILO) and the Institute of Human Development (IHD). While the BJP manifesto talks in general terms of increasing employment, self-employment and enhancing livelihood opportunities, besides enacting a strict law to stop misconduct in recruitment exams, the Congress has addressed the concern directly, making Yuva Nyay (justice for youth) one of the five 'pillars' of its manifesto, promising a right to apprenticeship with a stipend of Rs 1 lakh per year, filling up 3 million government vacancies and a one-time waiver of all educational debt.

Rahul is keen that these be communicated properly to the target audience. So, the Youth Congress has been assigned to distribute the party's guarantee cards, including these promises, to at least 10,000 households in every assembly segment. "The youth of this country are angry with the Modi government, which has failed them," says B.V. Srinivas, national president of the Youth Congress. "Our leader Rahul Gandhi naturally connects with the youth. We have seen overwhelming responses from the youth about our manifesto." Sensing the resonance the theme has among youth, other parties too have latched on to unemployment to lure the young voter. In Bihar, chief minister and Janata Dal (United) leader Nitish Kumar and his rival, Rashtriya Janata Dal leader Tejashwi Yadav, are claiming credit for the 500,000 government posts that were created in the 17-month mahagathbandhan government in which Tejashwi was deputy CM. In Maharashtra, the split factions of the Nationalist Congress Party and the Shiv Sena, which are ruling in alliance with the BJP, are also promising jobs and doles to youngsters.

It is not clear, though, how much impact unemployment will have on the election outcome, according to experts, even though nearly 60 per cent of the respondents aged between 18 and 24 in the India Today Mood of the Nation poll published in February termed the unemployment situation in the country as very serious. Vibha Attri and Jyoti Mishra, co-authors of the Lokniti-CSDS paper titled 'The Youth Vote in Lok Sabha Elections 2019', say a disconnect could accrue between employment and election results from the prioritisation of other themes. These, of course, can range from emotive identity issues and affiliations to positive conceptualisations to the national whole.

Experts aren't too sure about caste census as a plank. "It did not work even in the Hindi heartland states," says analyst Amitabh Tiwari

There is also a collective mistrust of political parties when it comes to solving the issue of unemployment. Varya Srivastava, a student at Oxford University and author of the upcoming *Ambition in Rising India*, says voters do not even expect any government to actively address the issue. "One reason for the indifference could be that the youth do not see the Opposition handling this situation properly. Besides, they see Modi's leadership as unmatchable," say Attri and Mishra. In the CSDS survey, six in 10 who find it hard to secure jobs assign responsibility to the state as well as central governments, while only two in 10 lay the blame on the doors of the central government.

Even Vaibhav Walia, chairman of the Congress's communication war room, partly agrees with this assessment. "On unemployment, people will not trust any party until and unless they see a doable and convincing plan. No political party in India has been able to crack the issue of unemployment, which is a global phenomenon. The Congress party, with great difficulty, has come up with a solution, which is short term," he says.